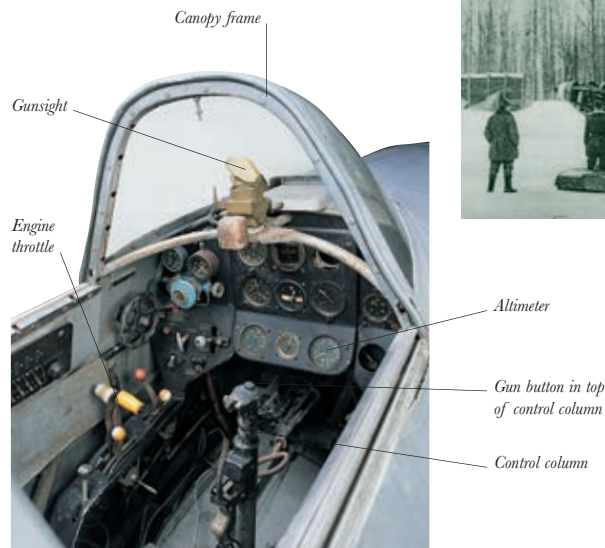


One of a family of fighters that stretched from the Yak-1 of 1939 to the impressive late-war Yak-9, the Yak-3 was the smallest, lightest Allied fighter flown during WW II. It was created by paring down the original Yak-1 in every conceivable way to reduce drag and weight, including replacing the oil cooler under the nose with twin coolers at the wing roots. The result was an aircraft with quick acceleration, a fine rate of climb, and excellent manoeuvrability. Its main drawback was its very light armament, which often prevented a kill when a Luftwaffe fighter was in a Soviet pilot's sights.

Like many successful Soviet aircraft, Yak-3s were no-frills machines, economical both to produce and to operate, and capable of flying from icebound, snow-covered airfields in the depths of the Russian winter. Almost 4,900 Yak-3s were manufactured in the course of the war, under the extremely primitive and trying conditions that prevailed in Soviet aircraft factories, relocated beyond the Ural mountains after the German invasion. The ultimate accolade was awarded to the Yak-3 by the pilots of the Free French Normandie-Niemen Squadron who fought with the Soviets on the Eastern Front from 1942 onward. In September 1944, given a choice of any American, British, or Soviet fighter to fly, they picked the Yak-3.

Single-seater
clear-view canopy

Coolant radiator
duct



CLEAR-VIEW COCKPIT

The Yak-3's cockpit was spacious for such a compact fighter, contributing to its popularity with pilots. The controls were light and responsive, and the straightforward clear-view canopy gave good all-around visibility.



SOVIET STAR

The Yak-3 fighters served the Soviet Union well in the desperate struggle for survival against the Nazi invaders. They operated more effectively under the harsh conditions of a Russian winter than the Luftwaffe's own fighter aircraft.

Free French
colors

Nose cannon

Exhaust stubs of
inline engine

Small oil
cooler

Undercarriage
protectors

Specifications

ENGINE 1,290hp Klimov VK-105PF2 liquid-cooled V12

WINGSPAN 30ft 2in (9.2m)

LENGTH 27ft 10in (8.5m)

WEIGHT 5,930lb (2,690kg)

TOP SPEED 404mph (650kph)

CREW 1

ARMAMENT 1 x nose-mounted 20mm ShVAK cannon;
2 x 12.7mm UBS machine guns

FREE FRENCH FIGHTERS

The Free French "Normandie-Niemen" fighter group, operating with Soviet forces on the Eastern Front, flew several Allied-built aircraft types, but preferred the Yak-3 over all others; the last 99 of their 273 air victories were obtained flying Yak-3s.

